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KOLKATA | Medium Pace

Tagore would not be pleased. Santiniketan, the abode of peace set up by the Nobel laureate, is seething following the leak of a hand-written March 9 note by Visva-Bharati Vice-Chancellor and institute head Rajat Kanta Roy which read: "To the Principal, Vidya Bhawan. With regard to the coming exam, English has been recommended by HLC and Academic Council as the medium and may now be implemented." The HLC is the high-level committee with the West Bengal governor as chairman which advises the vice-chancellor. Such advice is usually taken to be sacrosanct. But this instruction was close to heresy as it involved Santiniketan accepting the ascent of English over Bengali as the medium of instruction. Waves of protest from teachers and politicians led to rapid backtracking by the vice-chancellor. He now says any idea of making English the medium of instruction was only "poppytalk" and is denying the existence of his note. But the issue has already exploded. Bhromor Bhandari, Birbhum state secretary of the Chhatra Parishad, the frontal wing of the Congress, led a demonstration at the university followed by the CPI(M) student wing, SFI. The timing of the leak—May 7, the eve of Tagore's birth anniversary—too was most unfortunate for university authorities.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

A PROTEST AT SANTINIKETAN AGAINST MAKING ENGLISH THE MEDIUM OF INSTRUCTION

88

years ago Santiniketan, which means 'abode of peace', was expanded from a college into an university.